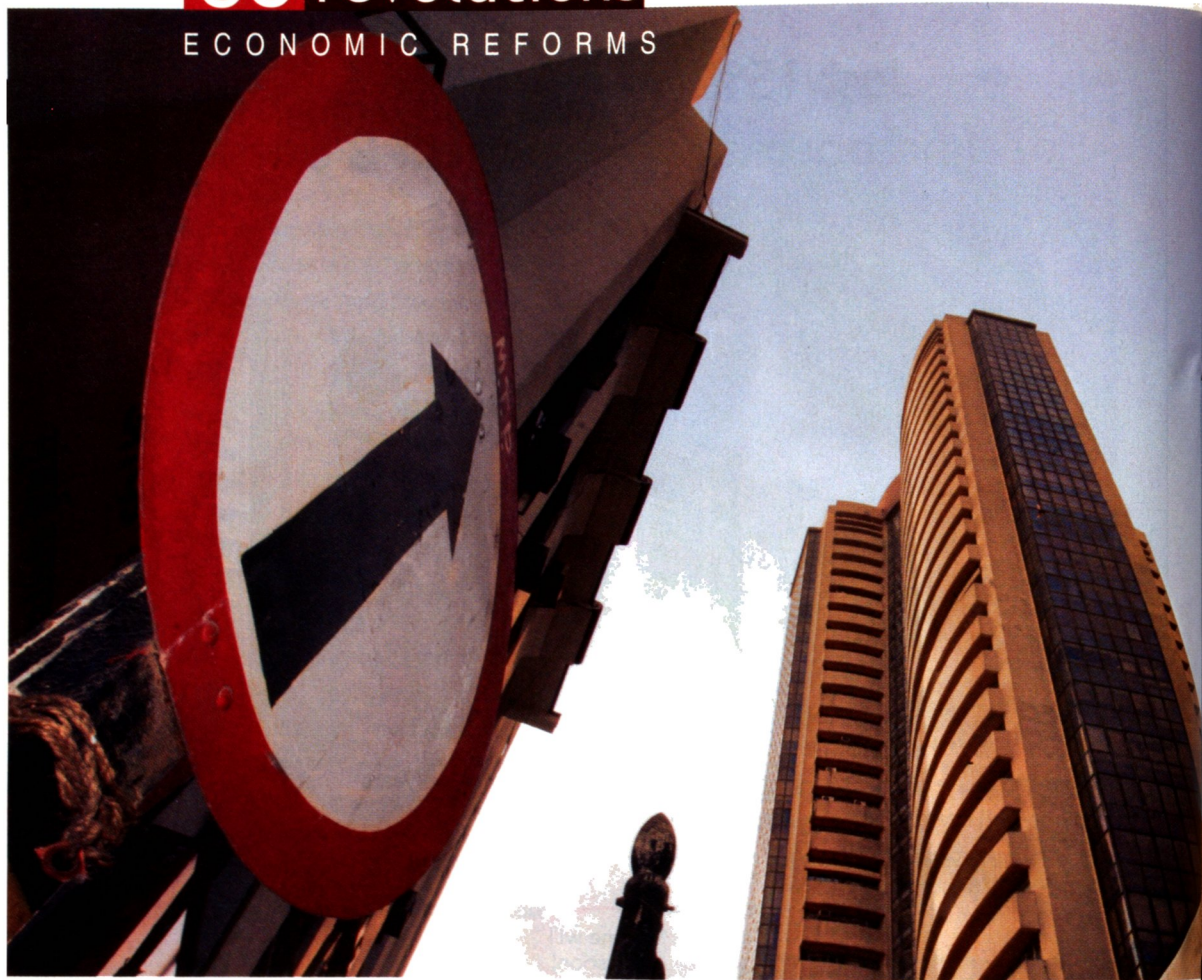


60 WINDS OF CHANGE revolutions

ECONOMIC REFORMS



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India has come a long way from the days of waiting eight years for a scooter and pleading with MPs for a quota phone. A combination of crisis, the political audacity of P.V. Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh's ideas, delivered economic freedom, the privilege of choice to Indians.

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

It couldn't get more kaleidoscopic. Every twist of the radial brings forth a new view of a booming economy. Be it the image of a young workforce adding value to a trillion-dollar economy, the debate on what to do with the burgeoning forex reserves or the headlines dominated by desi companies taking over multinationals. Any which way you look, the success of liberalisation is only too visible. The neon signs, the mall fronts, the glossy ads, the commercials tripping on TRPs are all symbols of unquestionable success.

Of economic freedom, nay privilege of choice.

It is almost as if there couldn't have been any other way. Indeed for nearly 450 million Indians, born after the July 1991 revolution, this is the only India they know. For the other half of the populace which lived through licence raj, it is a continuing journey of wonderment. From a time when choosing a car meant selecting either a black Ambassador or a white Premier Padmini to choosing between a mauve Cayenne or a lavender i10. When flying